General rule – cover · "Playing the Game" chapter of SRD 5.2.1

Walls, trees, creatures and other obstacles can give **cover**: protection against attacks and some effects. There are three degrees: **Half Cover**, **Three-Quarters Cover** and **Total Cover**. If several obstacles apply, only the **most protective** counts.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. **Half Cover**: +2 to AC and Dexterity saves.
2. **Three-Quarters**: +5 to AC and Dexterity saves.
3. **Total Cover**: can't be targeted directly.
4. Only the **strongest** degree of cover applies.

⚠ Change from 2014

The 2024 text is clearer: cover is judged from **the attacker** or the effect's origin, and only the strongest counts. Creatures can give cover.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't define "half the body" precisely. Fix: the DM announces the cover degree before the roll.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the obstacle (low wall, trunk, barrel) so the table understands why AC changes.

Step 1 – Spot the obstacle:

Draw a line from the attacker (or the effect's origin) to the target: what's in the way?

Step 2 – Determine the degree:

An obstacle covering about half the body: Half; about three-quarters: Three-Quarters; all: Total.

Step 3 – Apply the bonus:

Add +2 or +5 to AC and Dexterity saves against an effect that crosses the obstacle.

Step 4 – Total Cover:

The target can't be targeted by an attack or spell that names it; an area effect can still reach it if it enters the area.

Step 5 – Several obstacles:

Keep only the **best** cover: no adding up.

Example: an archer behind a low wall (Half Cover): AC 14 becomes 16 against arrows; behind an arrow slit (Three-Quarters): AC 19.

Degree	Effect
Half Cover	+2 to AC and Dex saves (low wall, furniture, creature)
Three-Quarters	+5 to AC and Dex saves (arrow slit, thick trunk)
Total Cover	Can't be targeted directly (full wall, closed door)

Examples of obstacles

Degree	Common obstacles
Half Cover	Low wall, furniture, barrel, thin trunk, creature
Three-Quarters	Arrow slit, pillar, thick trunk, wall corner
Total Cover	Full wall, closed door, boulder, solid opaque curtain

⚠ Common questions:

Does a creature give cover?

Yes: Half Cover, even an ally.

Do several obstacles stack?

No: only the best counts.

Does cover apply to saves?

Yes: only Dexterity saves.

A spell targeting "a creature you can see"?

You need a line of sight; Total Cover prevents it.

Cover and melee attacks?

Applies if an obstacle is between you (window, low wall).

Fireball and cover?

Cover protects based on the burst's origin.

Cover and spell attack rolls?

Yes: +2 or +5 to AC against the attack.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Adjacent creature

Does an adjacent foe give cover? **Option**: only if their body blocks the line.

Shifting partial cover

A moving obstacle: **Option**: reassess each attack.

Transparent obstacle

Glass doesn't block sight but blocks projectiles. **Option**: Total Cover.

Cover and reach

A reach weapon over an obstacle. **Option**: Half Cover.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Allies in front

An allied creature between you and the target can give Half Cover.

Dexterity

The cover bonus adds to Dex saves against effects from the other side.

Area spells

Cover only protects if the effect's origin is on the far side of the obstacle.

Line of sight

Total Cover blocks line of sight; without line of sight, no direct targeting.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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